

energy; then, at the resurrection of the righteous, your own body will be brought to life and resurrected incorruptible and glorified like that of Christ, as the divine Apostle writes to the Philippians: "Who shall change our lowly body, that it may be fashioned like unto His glorious body" (Phil. 3:21).

All of these great and supranatural dignities and graces of which we have spoken until now are received by every Christian who partakes of the divine Mysteries of our sweetest Jesus Christ with a pure conscience; and indeed even more than these are received, which we have not mentioned for the sake of brevity.

After one receives Communion, he thinks about the dread and heavenly Mysteries of which he partook, and so he takes heed to himself so as not to dishonor that grace. He fears his thoughts [*logismoi*], shrinks away from them, and protects himself from them. He begins a more correct and virtuous life, and, as much as is possible, abstains from every evil. When he begins to think about the fact that he will be receiving Communion again in just a few days, he doubles his efforts to watch over himself. He adds zeal to zeal, self-control to self-control, vigilance to vigilance, labors upon labors, and he struggles as much as possible. This is because he is pressed on two sides: on one side, because just a short while ago he received Communion, and on the other, because he will receive again in just a short while.

CHAPTER 3

Infrequent Communion Causes Great Harm

Infrequent Communion brings the complete opposite upon Christians. For whoever puts off receiving Communion does not perform a single preparation. He is not careful, and he does not guard himself from evil thoughts very well. This is because procrastination causes him to fall into negligence, and causes the warmth of piety and divine love to grow cold. The long period of abstinence gives him the opportunity to leisurely and carelessly walk through life, without having fear in his soul, without reining in his senses, and without watching carefully over his actions. But, rather, he allows himself to have total license with regard to food, words, and improper sights and sounds, and to become like a horse without a bridle, falling over every precipice of sin. All of these things indeed happen to those who put off receiving Communion, as we know from our own daily trial and experience.

I truly wonder how those who are worthy (as much as is possible, that is) to receive Communion, but put it off, are able to receive sanctification and grace from the divine Mysteries as Cabasilas described earlier. How can they extinguish the flame of the passions when they do not commune in the immaculate Mysteries, which according to the sacred Cyril drive away every illness, subdue the fierce war of the flesh, and deaden the passions?

How can they purify their intellects, enlighten their minds, or adorn any of the powers of their souls without partaking of the body and blood of our Lord, which according

to the divine Chrysostom is the true purification, beauty, and enlightenment of the soul and its nobility, as we have read?

And how is it possible for them to flee the noetic Pharaoh, bitter Egypt, and dark sin, when they are not anointed and sealed with the precious blood of Christ, as Gregory the Theologian has described? And by what means can they ignite the flame of divine love in their hearts and receive spiritual joy, divine peace, and the other fruits and charismata of the Holy Spirit without receiving the body and blood of the Father's beloved Son, Who is of one essence with the Holy Spirit, and Who, according to the Apostle, is our true joy and peace and the fount of all good things?

I am bewildered and wonder over how today's Christians can celebrate Sundays and the other Feasts of the year and spiritually rejoice with true joy without frequently partaking of divine Communion, which is the reason and occasion for every Feast and celebration.

So, it is most certain that those who do not frequently commune are deprived (O, what a tragedy!) of all these heavenly and divine blessings. Furthermore, they are also transgressors of the commandments and of the decrees of the Lord, as we previously said, and of the Apostolic and Conciliar Canons, and of all of the teachings of the Saints which we have presented. And they are subject to the excommunication prescribed by the divine Apostles and the Council in Antioch, as we also have spoken about at length.

By procrastinating and not receiving Communion, such people also give the devil permission and opportunity to cast them into various sins and many other temptations, as

the divine Cyril of Alexandria says: "Those who distance themselves from the Church and Communion become enemies of God and friends of the demons."¹¹⁹

In the words of the divine Chrysostom: "...that I may not, by long abstaining from Thy Communion, become prey to the noetic wolf."¹²⁰ That is: "For this reason, Lord, I frequently approach the Mysteries and partake, because I fear that, if I distance myself from Your Holy Communion for a long time, that noetic wolf, the devil, will find me bereft of Your grace and kill me."

The Righteous Palladios learned from Abba Makarios of Egypt that after he healed a certain woman (who by the workings of the devil appeared like a horse to the eyes of men) he gave her the following counsel: "You should never be absent from the Communion of the Mysteries of Christ, but should commune frequently, for this diabolic thing happened to you because you did not receive Communion for five weeks, and thus the devil found an opportunity to tempt you."¹²¹

¹¹⁹ *De exitu animi*, PG 77, 1088B.

¹²⁰ Third Prayer before Holy Communion; trans. *A Prayer Book for Orthodox Christians*, 342. [Translator's note: In this same prayer, St. John Chrysostom also says that Holy Communion is a "defence against every operation of the devil" (Ibid., 341). And in the Seventh Prayer before Holy Communion, St. Symeon the New Theologian says that we must partake of the blameless Mysteries,

"Lest that foul deceiver find me,
All bereft of Thy divine grace,
And most guiltfully seduce me,
And with scheming cunning lure me,

From Thy words which make me Godlike. (Ibid., 347-348)]

¹²¹ Cf. *Historia Lausiac*, chs. 19, 20, PG 34, 1049A; *Palladius: The Lausiac*

Likewise, on the day of his ordination, the divine Chrysostom healed a demoniac and admonished him to go to Church and receive the divine Mysteries frequently, with fasting and prayers,¹²² so that the demon might not bother him again. This is written in the *Life* of St. John Chrysostom by Symeon Metaphrastes:

A certain man who had an unclean demon suddenly jumped into the midst of the Church. Falling to the ground, he was foaming at the mouth with his tongue hanging out. All who were present witnessing such a sight fervently asked the holy and divine Chrysostom to supplicate God to heal the possessed man. The Saint told the man to come to him. As soon as he placed his hand upon him and called upon the Name of the Holy Trinity, looking upon him compassionately, he commanded the demon to come out of him. Immediately—O, what wonder!—his word took effect, and the man was straightway liberated from the terrible illness of the demon. After the Saint lifted him up off of the ground, he counseled him to attend Church, go to divine Communion, and to practice asceticism with fasting and prayer. He said: "If you live in this manner, you will never be bothered by the enemy again, nor will you be caught by the demonic traps and ambushes."

Do you hear, my brethren, what evils are suffered by those who do not frequently commune, but rather distance themselves from the Mysteries? Do you hear that they become possessed by demons and are changed into the

¹²² *History* (New York: Paulist Press, ACW, 1964), 56–57.
Cf. Mk. 9:29.

likeness of irrational beasts, just like when of old king Nebuchadnezzar was changed into the likeness of an ox?¹²³ And they justly suffer these things. For they, although men, are able to become gods by grace by frequently partaking of divine Communion; and they do not want to, but keeping themselves from divine Communion, lose their human form and are changed into irrational beasts, and hand themselves over to the authority of Satan, as the Psalmist says: "For behold, they that remove themselves from Thee shall perish" (Ps. 72:25). That is, "O Lord, behold, those who distance themselves from Your grace are completely lost."

If sudden death comes upon those who put off Communion and finds them unprepared, not having received the Mysteries, what will happen to these poor people? How will they be able to travel freely past those toll-collectors of the air, the demons? What fear and terror will their soul experience? And they would have been able to be freed of all these things through frequent Communion, as the divine Chrysostom said earlier. Be merciful, O God!

So, my brothers, since infrequent Communion brings us so many great and inexpressible evils, while frequent Communion grants us such lofty, great, heavenly, and supernatural good things, in both the present and future life, why do we delay so much to receive it? Why should we not prepare ourselves properly to commune in the divine Mysteries, if not daily, then every Saturday or Sunday and at every Feast? We should, with great joy, run frequently to the sacred Table to receive our sweetest Jesus Christ, our whole life and breath, our entire hope and salvation, so that

¹²³ Cf. Dan. 4:33.

we may always be united to and inseparable from Him, in both this life and the next. But, on the contrary, we are content as we are, and we take great joy in procrastinating and keeping ourselves away from Him.

If someone were to deprive us of the table of bodily foods for just one day, we would become sad and restless, and think it was something terrible. But if we are deprived of the spiritual and heavenly Table of the divine Mysteries for one or two days, for entire months, we do not consider it to be bad. What a great lack of discrimination today's Christians exercise regarding bodily things and spiritual ones! For they embrace the things of the body with all their love, yet do not at all desire the things of the spirit.

Many God-loving Christians expend a great deal of money, labor greatly, and endure many dangers, both by sea and by land, in order to go and venerate the Life-giving Tomb of the Lord in Jerusalem, and other holy places. And then they boast that they can call themselves "pilgrims" who have venerated at these sacred sites. Many who hear that there is to be found in a far away place a sacred relic of a certain Saint run with great eagerness to go and venerate it, in order to receive grace and sanctification.

But when it comes to partaking of the immaculate Mysteries and being deemed worthy to enjoy, not the Life-giving Tomb, not holy places, not relics of Saints, but the King of all and the Holy of Holies, they have scant desire, or it does not interest them at all. In order to visit the holy sites, much money must be spent, long roads must be traversed, and many dangers must be endured. On the other hand, in order to commune, money is not required, nor does one have to walk very far, nor does one have to undergo dangers.

It is enough to make a contrite confession, fulfill a sound rule, and prepare properly, and immediately one can receive Communion and become one body and one blood with Christ. Yet, even with the ease of this, everyone is still negligent concerning Communion and declines it.¹²⁴

Alas, my brothers! If we could but once see with the noetic eyes of our soul of what lofty and great blessings we are deprived by not frequently communing, then, indeed, we would do everything in our power to prepare ourselves to receive Communion, every day if it were possible.¹²⁵

¹²⁴ Translator's note: St. Nikodemos writes something very similar in his book, *Chrestothēia Ion Christianon* [*Christian Morality*]:

I know that many of you Christians think it a great blessing and cause for boasting to go to Jerusalem and reverently and compunctionately venerate the holy pilgrimage sites there, namely, the Life-receiving Tomb of the Lord, holy Golgotha, sacred Bethlehem, and the rest. Many of you travel to far away places, toiling over land and sea, in order to piously venerate the sacred relics of many Saints.... Indeed, such a reverent pilgrimage and piety and journey is good and praiseworthy. But should you not have, brothers, if not greater piety, at least the same amount of piety and reverence, when you go to and attend the Church of Christ, where all of the pilgrimage sites found at Jerusalem are present symbolically? Should you not show the same compunction and good order and respect when you attend the dread and divine Liturgy at which you find present, not the relic of such and such a Saint, but the very life-giving and divine [*theoppositon*] and wholly-undefiled body and blood of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Holy of Holies? (Homily 12.2 [Thessaloniki: Regopoulos, 1999], 315-316)

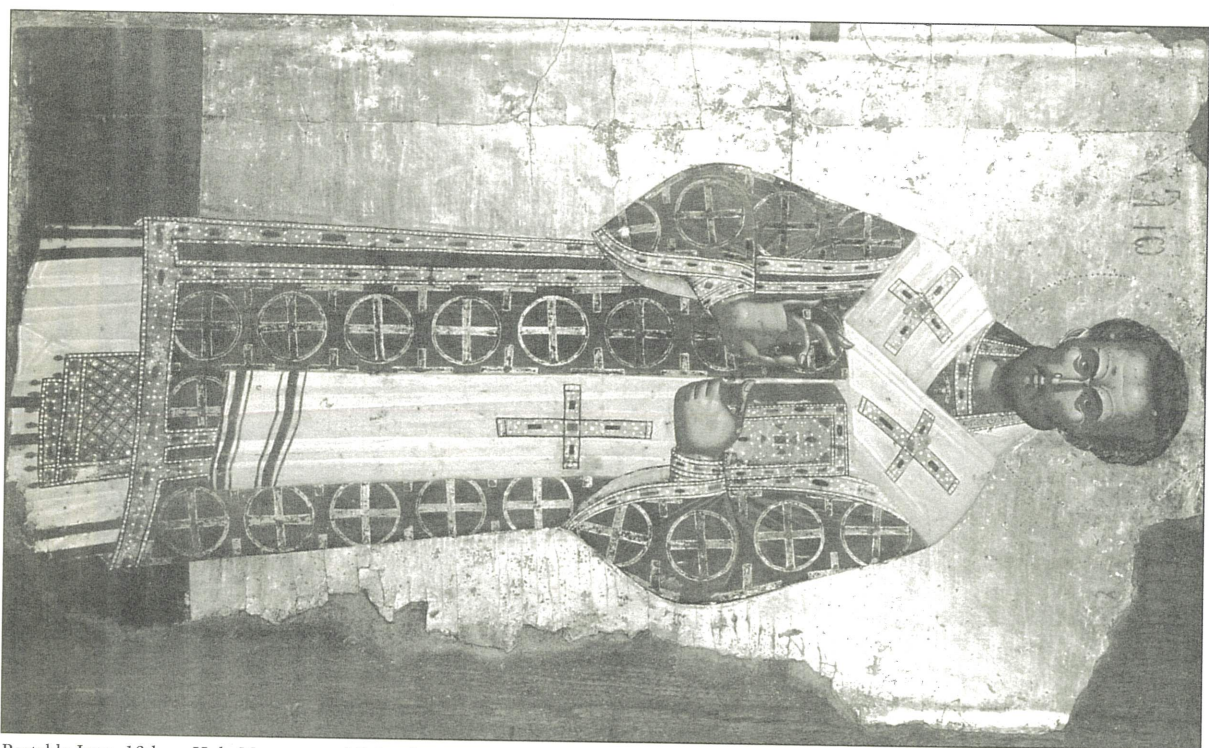
¹²⁵ Translator's note: Commenting upon the Ninth Ode of the Canon of Great and Holy Thursday, St. Nikodemos exhorts us:

Come, O faithful Christians, and having previously purified ourselves through the appropriate preparation—having confessed our sins,

So, if we have displayed great negligence until now regarding Holy Communion, I ask with brotherly love from the bottom of my heart: from now on, let us awake from the deep slumber of sloth and acquire eagerness and diligence. And if someone possessing spiritual authority wishes to obstruct us from this virtuous work, let us not allow the fervor of our eagerness to grow cold right away. No. Rather, falling down, let us kiss his feet like the harlot¹²⁶ and persistently knock on the door seeking permission. I most certainly do not believe that there is to be found anyone so hard of heart that, seeing such fervent desire for Holy Communion, he would prohibit us. Rather, I am certain that, no matter how hard-hearted he may be, or how intimidated by the bad custom to which he has adhered until now, his heart will be inclined to permit us to fulfill our desire.

for given our enemies, and put away all hate — and being adorned by a pure conscience, thus let us draw near to the divine Mysteries and enjoy the Master's hospitality; that is, let us enjoy the hospitality that the Master Christ prepares for us today, and the immortal and spiritual table set for those who are worthy. For He feeds us with His incorruptible and wholly-undefiled body, and He gives us to drink His incorruptible and life-giving blood. (*Heortodromion*, vol. 2 [1995], 165)

¹²⁶ Cf. Lk. 7:37–38.



Portable Icon, 16th c., Holy Monastery of Grigoriou, Mount Athos

Saint John Chrysostom